A Court Ruling, but Families Are Still Waiting for Visas

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For almost a year, a family has been split between two countries while it waits for one piece of paper: a **visa**. Dustin Hoffman, a U.S. Army veteran, started the paperwork late last year so his wife, Gloria, could live in the United States. Gloria, who is from Colombia, stayed in Argentina with their 5-year-old daughter, Chaya, and Hoffman's 12-year-old stepson, Israel. Hoffman says he misses them every day. In January, the Trump administration stopped processing **immigrant visas** for citizens of 75 countries. Many people were already partway through the process, and some had already been approved and were only waiting for the **visa** itself. Gloria is from Colombia, one of the countries on the list. In August, a **federal** judge ordered the ban to be lifted, but the Hoffman family still has not received its **visa**. The State Department has continued to ask for more proof that the family can support itself without public help. Lawyers for migrants say the family shows a wider problem. They say that, in practice, the court order has not ended the wait, because interviews and **visa** stamps are still moving slowly. The State Department declined to comment, saying the matter is in pending **litigation**, while its website says the ban is no longer in effect. The ban affected more than 280,000 people who had applied by January, according to the report. A Cato Institute analysis said it targeted thousands of close family members of U.S. citizens and permanent residents, and called it one of the most extreme legal immigration policies in U.S. history. Another applicant, Colombian researcher Dr. Fernando Lizcano, who was found qualified for an **extraordinary**-ability **visa**, is also still in Colombia waiting for final approval.

Word Treasure

visa -- An official paper that lets a person enter or live in another country.
immigrant -- Relating to people who move to another country to live there.
federal -- Relating to the national government of a country.
litigation -- A legal case being argued in court.
extraordinary -- Very unusual and much greater than normal.

Background you need

A visa is an official paper that lets a person enter and live in another country, and an immigrant visa is for someone who plans to move there for good.

Families usually apply, show papers, and wait for an interview and a final stamp before they can travel.

A court can order a government rule to stop, but offices must still carry out each step, so waiting can go on even after a ruling.

Governments also ask applicants to show they can support themselves, so officials may ask for more proof before they finish a case.

Break it down

LEAD: A family has waited almost a year for a visa that would let Gloria live in the United States.

KEY EVENT: In January, processing stopped for citizens of 75 countries, including Colombia.

+- WHO: Dustin Hoffman, his wife Gloria, their daughter Chaya, and Hoffman's stepson Israel.

+- WHERE: Gloria and the children stayed in Argentina.

+- WHEN: A federal judge ordered the ban lifted in August, but the visa still had not arrived.

EVIDENCE: Lawyers say interviews and visa stamps are still moving slowly; the State Department's website says the ban is no longer in effect.

OPEN QUESTION: When will the Hoffman family and other waiting applicants receive their visas?

Why it matters

This matters because a visa decision can decide whether a family lives together or apart, and a court ruling does not always end a long wait on its own.

Test what you remember

1. **Who started the paperwork so Gloria could live in the United States?**
   - (A) Dr. Fernando Lizcano
   - (B) Dustin Hoffman
   - (C) Gloria
   - (D) A federal judge
2. **Where did Gloria stay with the children?**
   - (A) The United States
   - (B) Colombia
   - (C) Argentina
   - (D) Florida
3. **In which month did the administration stop processing immigrant visas for citizens of 75 countries?**
   - (A) December
   - (B) August
   - (C) January
   - (D) October
4. **What did a federal judge order in August?**
   - (A) More proof to be dropped
   - (B) The visa to be printed at once
   - (C) The ban to be lifted
   - (D) The family to move at once
5. **According to lawyers for migrants, why has the wait not ended?**
   - (A) No one applied for a visa
   - (B) The family withdrew its application
   - (C) The ban was never lifted
   - (D) Interviews and visa stamps are still moving slowly
6. **How many people who had applied by January were affected by the ban, according to the report?**
   - (A) Exactly 75,000 people
   - (B) Fewer than 1,000 people
   - (C) About 5,000 people
   - (D) More than 280,000 people

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: C 4: C 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Lawyers for migrants: They say the case shows a wider problem and that, in practice, the court order has not ended the wait.

2. State Department: It declined to comment because the matter is in pending litigation, while its website says the ban is no longer in effect.

3. Cato Institute analysis: It said the ban targeted thousands of close family members of U.S. citizens and permanent residents and called it one of the most extreme legal immigration policies in U.S. history.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):